

American Elm

Ulmus americana



Origin

Native to eastern North America; once the single most-planted street tree in the United States, forming iconic tree-lined 'elm tunnels' over countless American streets before the mid-20th century.

Look for

Fold a leaf in half at its base -- the two sides won't line up, because American elm leaves have distinctly uneven bases, a reliable ID trait year-round.

IDENTIFICATION TIPS

- Leaf: toothed, lopsided base -- fold in half and the two sides won't match.
- Crown: tall, arching, wineglass or vase silhouette.
- Seed: flat, round seed disks (samaras) in spring.
- Commonly confused with: Chinese elm (American elm's bark is deeply furrowed rather than mottled and peeling).

THROUGH THE SEASONS

Spring	Small red-green flowers bloom before leaves, followed by flat, round seed disks.
Summer	Large, toothed, lopsided leaves form the tree's signature arching vase shape.
Fall	Leaves turn bright yellow.
Winter	The tall, arching, wineglass-shaped silhouette is most visible with leaves gone.

DID YOU KNOW

- Dutch elm disease, a fungus spread by bark beetles, killed the majority of America's mature street elms between the 1930s and 1980s, changing the look of American streets forever.
- A small number of naturally disease-tolerant elms survived and have since been used to breed newer, more resistant elm cultivars now being replanted in some cities.